

People Analytics Needs to Evolve Beyond Reporting

People Analytics (PA):

Also referred to as HR or talent analytics, people analytics refers to the process of collecting and analyzing people-related data for the purpose of producing insights that improve decision making and business outcomes.

People analytics generally includes the use of investigative techniques, statistical methodologies, various technologies, and analytical expertise.

[Many organizations](#) have improved workforce reporting capabilities through dashboards, AI-enabled tools, and expanded access to workforce data. However, the findings suggest that organizations are improving reporting capabilities faster than their ability to translate workforce insights into meaningful business action.

Across all three Delphi rounds, experts consistently emphasize that the future value of people analytics depends less on reporting sophistication and more on operational influence, business relevance, and decision support. Yet many organizations continue to struggle to translate insights into measurable business outcomes. [Last year's research](#) on this topic shows that only 45% of HR professionals say their people analytics systems improve talent and business outcomes, continuing a multi-year challenge in gaining operational influence.

Experts emphasize the need for operational influence

In the first Delphi round, experts repeatedly argue that people analytics must evolve beyond historical reporting and become more closely integrated with organizational decision-making.

Several participants describe a future where people analytics functions act as “decision accelerators,” helping leaders respond faster to workforce risks, operational challenges, and business priorities.

Fiona Jamison, VP Research & People Analytics at People Results, describes this evolution clearly:

“The role will shift from primarily analyzing what has happened to proactively guiding leaders on what to do next, integrating AI-enabled insights, scenario modeling, and real-time signals to support workforce transformation, AI adoption, and organizational effectiveness at scale.”

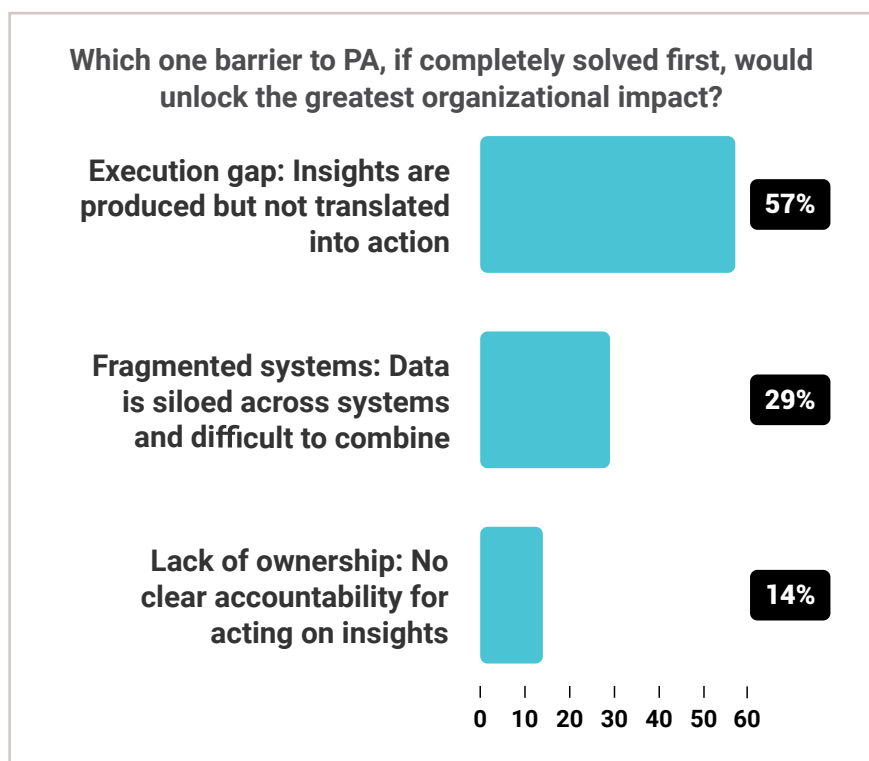
Lisa I. Perez, SPHR, SHRM-SCP, Founder and CEO of HBL Resources, similarly emphasizes the importance of moving beyond fragmented reporting and toward operational visibility and accountability:

“The goal is to move from hindsight to near real-time visibility, so leaders can make decisions based on current conditions, not last month’s compiled reports, and take action faster with clear ownership, outcomes and accountability.”

Curtis Winegar, Sr. Data Analytics Strategist at Pella Corporation, adds:

“The goal is to move people analytics from reporting what happened to helping leaders and teams make better decisions, develop capabilities faster, and deliver results more consistently.”

This execution challenge becomes even clearer in the final Delphi round. When asked which single barrier, if completely solved first, would unlock the greatest organizational impact, the largest share of experts select the execution gap: insights are produced but not translated into action.



The Execution Gap:

The 'execution gap' in people analytics refers to organizations generating data but struggling to turn it into tangible operational change.

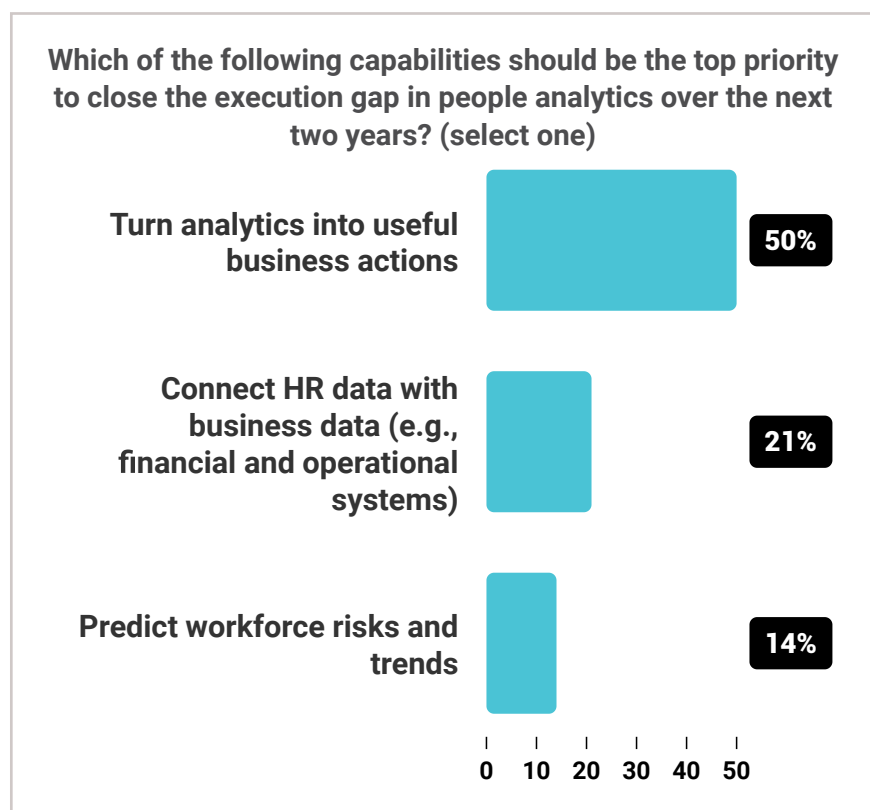
High-Impact Team: A 'high-impact' people analytics team is one that measurably influences business strategy and outcomes, rather than operating merely as a reactive reporting desk.

Decision Activation: Partnering directly with business leaders to turn insights into measurable action plans.

Decision activation emerges as the top execution priority

The second and third Delphi rounds explore solutions to closing this execution gap. In Round 2, 67% of experts identify decision activation as one of the top capabilities organizations should prioritize to close the execution gap in people analytics.

In the final Delphi round when asked to prioritize only one capability to close this execution gap, half of the panelists select turning analytics into useful business actions as the single most important capability organizations should prioritize over the next two years. By comparison, only 21% select connecting HR and business data systems, while 14% prioritize predictive workforce analytics.



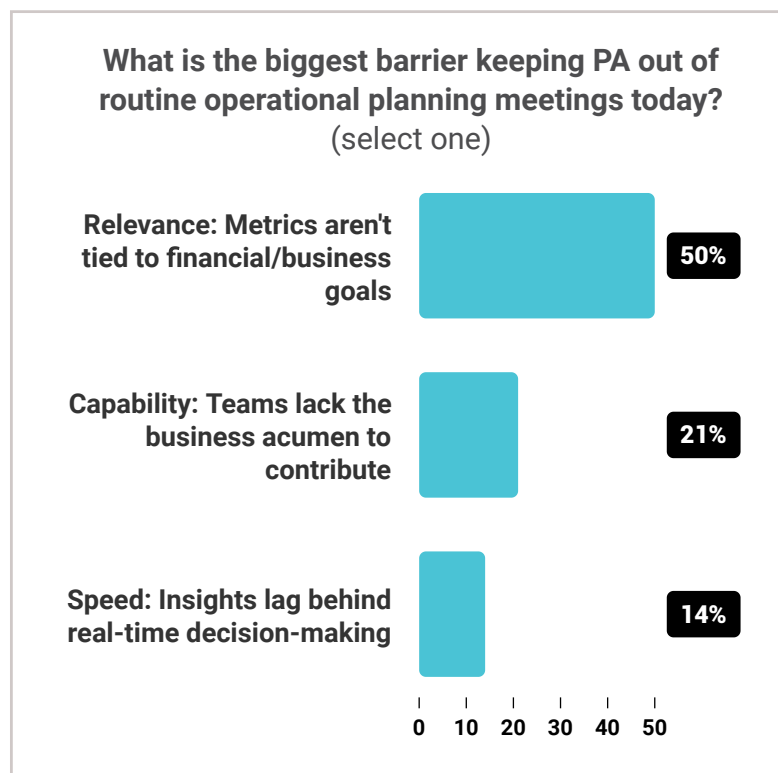
Note: Options chosen by less than 10% of respondents were not included in this chart.

High-impact teams embed analytics into operational workflows

When asked in Round 2 which factors most clearly define a high-impact function, the panel generated a three-way statistical tie at 58% each. Experts evenly select embedding analytics into routine leadership and operational planning meetings, starting analyses based on specific business problems and measuring success through business impact and follow-through rather than report usage.

These findings suggest that analytics influence depends heavily on proximity to decision-making. Teams that operate separately from operational planning cycles often struggle to influence business outcomes regardless of analytical sophistication.

By Round 3, experts identify **relevance** as the biggest barrier preventing people analytics from participating in operational planning meetings. Half of respondents say workforce metrics often fail to connect clearly enough to financial or business goals, while 21% point to insufficient business acumen within analytics teams.



Structural and behavioral barriers continue limiting impact

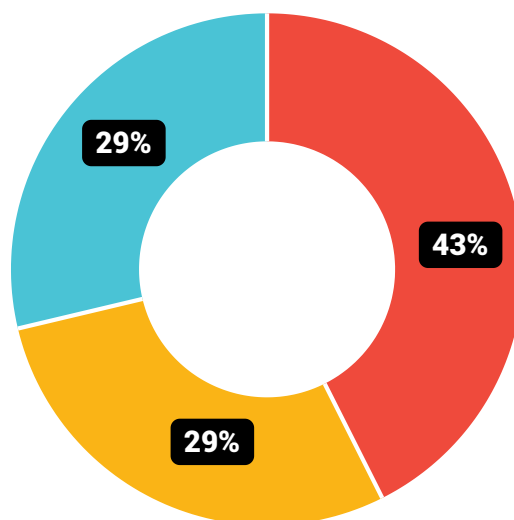
The final Delphi round also asks experts how organizations should build this capability. Rather than recommending large-scale enterprise transformation, experts favor a more focused and practical approach. Twenty-nine percent recommend concentrating first on solving a small number of major business problems, such as turnover or hiring, while 21% support building specialized centralized people analytics teams. Another 21% advocate combining centralized expertise with targeted business problem-solving.

The advisory board discussions reinforce this conclusion. Helen Friedman, Partner and Chief Executive Officer at Merit Analytics Group LLC, argues that organizations often focus too heavily on analytics themselves while overlooking change management and leadership adoption. *She notes that leaders frequently resist findings that challenge personal perspectives or existing practices.*

Similarly, Shane McGowan, People Analytics Business Partner at LifeStance Health, explains that HR analytics often lacks the operational visibility routinely given to finance and sales functions.

This evolution points to a clear structural direction in the final survey round. When forced to define the single primary role of the people analytics function over the next two years, 43% of experts select Strategic Advisor (guiding executive strategy with workforce insights and research). The remainder of the panel is evenly split at 29% each between acting as a Data Integrator (connecting HR, finance, and operations systems) and an Embedded Partner (delivering real-time insights straight to managers and teams).

What should be the primary role of the people analytics function over the next two years? (select one)



- **Strategic Advisor: Guide executive strategy with workforce insights and research**
- **Data Integrator: Connect HR, finance, and operational data systems**
- **Embedded Partner: Deliver real-time workforce insights to managers and teams**

Note: numbers do not add up to 100% due to rounding.

Ultimately, the research points toward a substantial evolution in the mandate of people analytics. The function can no longer operate as a passive, defensive reporting center; instead, industry leaders demand a strategic advisory capability that helps executives interpret workforce signals, anticipate organizational risks, and drive measurable outcomes.

HRRI Strategic Recommendations

Based on our research, please consider the following suggestions:

1. **Embed analytics into operational routines.** Organizations should involve analytics teams earlier in business planning cycles rather than after decisions have already been made. Include people analytics teams in:
 - workforce planning discussions
 - operational review meetings
 - quarterly business reviews
 - succession planning conversations
2. **Start with business problems rather than reporting requests.** Analytics efforts create greater value when they focus on solving operational and workforce challenges rather than producing additional dashboards. Encourage analytics teams to frame projects around operational questions such as:
 - Which teams face the highest turnover risk?
 - Where are capability gaps slowing execution?
 - Which leadership behaviors improve retention?
3. **Create accountability for action.** This helps close the execution gap identified throughout the study. Many organizations generate insights but fail to establish ownership for follow-through. Consider:
 - assigning decision owners for major findings
 - requiring action plans tied to analytics insights
 - reviewing workforce actions during leadership meetings
4. **Build analytics fluency across leadership teams.** The goal is to make analytics part of everyday operational thinking rather than a specialist activity. Organizations can strengthen adoption by:
 - training HR professionals and leaders on analytics interpretation
 - creating simple business-focused storytelling templates
 - developing shared definitions for key metrics
 - teaching leaders how to use analytics during planning discussions
5. **Measure business outcomes, not reporting activity.** This reinforces the idea that analytics exists to improve decisions, not simply increase reporting volume. Evaluate people analytics based on outcomes such as:
 - turnover reduction
 - productivity improvement
 - stronger internal mobility
 - leadership effectiveness
 - hiring efficiency